The Ballot or the Bullet

Malcolm X · Cleveland, OH (April 3, 1964) & Detroit (April 12, 1964) · excerpts

Source: Reprinted in Malcolm X Speaks: Selected Speeches and Statements (ed. George Breitman, 1965).

Three weeks after breaking with the Nation of Islam, Malcolm X delivered this speech in Cleveland and again in Detroit. He framed 1964 as a watershed election year and argued that Black Americans had to use either the ballot or, failing that, the bullet — the right of self-defense. The speech marked Malcolm's pivot from Nation-of-Islam separatism toward broader Black nationalism and the international human-rights frame he would develop in the months before his assassination in February 1965.

Connect: Malcolm X's rejection of nonviolence echoes David Walker's 1829 Appeal (Class 19) — both Black leaders argued for self-defense. What continues, and what has changed?

Key Passages

The diagnosis

> I'm not a politician, not even a student of politics; in fact, I'm not a student of much of anything. I'm not a Democrat. I'm not a Republican, and I don't even consider myself an American. … No, I'm not an American. I'm one of the 22 million Black people who are the victims of Americanism.

Ballot or bullet

> 1964 threatens to be the most explosive year America has ever witnessed. … It's the year when all of the white political crooks will be right back in your and my community … trying to bamboozle you and me. … It'll be the ballot or it'll be the bullet.

On self-defense

> I don't even call it violence when it's self-defense, I call it intelligence.

On nonviolence

> Concerning nonviolence: it is criminal to teach a man not to defend himself when he is the constant victim of brutal attacks.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	1964: the Civil Rights Act was stalled by a Senate filibuster, frustration with slow progress was growing, and Malcolm X had just left the Nation of Islam.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Black Americans in Northern cities, especially those frustrated with nonviolence; the speeches were given in churches in Cleveland and Detroit.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Malcolm X, a Black nationalist leader who emphasized self-defense and Black political power, and who saw white liberals and politicians as unreliable.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — compare branches of the CRM: Identify ONE significant similarity AND ONE difference between Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr. in 1964.

2. What does Malcolm X mean by saying he is 'not an American'?

3. How did Malcolm's views shift in the year between this speech and his assassination?